

B2B operations, are now looking at automation as a means for expansion in B2B2C segments. While India may be far away from fully robotic warehouses, autonomous carts in the aisles and driverless trucks, several basic, repetitive and low-efficiency jobs are already getting automated.

Sure, the positives of AI intervention cannot be denied, but it begs the question: Is it threatening jobs in the sector? Are we re-entering an era of man-versus-machine? “That’s unlikely in the near future,” says Vaishnav Shetty, Chief Digital Officer at Allcargo Logistics. “We work with several companies where manpower has been significantly reduced (more than 80 per cent in some cases) as a result of robotics and automation. However, a completely zero-touch model is still some time away, especially

in B2B facilities,” he says. Agrees Saigal: “Some of the most basic jobs will be automated because the scale and volume of shipments today is so high that it’s manually impossible to handle. But what works in logistics is the right combination of man and machine to deliver real value at the right cost.”

Automation, therefore, is improving the size of the pie and enhancing the quality of human intervention. It is creating new “value-add roles” that can collaborate with the machines. Not only will companies get more done in less time now, they can also log more revenues per hour and pay their workers better.

Sounds like logistics utopia. **BT**

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Robot in my Cart

AI IS TRANSFORMING CONSUMER GOODS AND RETAIL COMPANIES, AND THEIR BUSINESS MODELS, AT UNPRECEDENTED LEVELS

BY ARNAB DUTTA

